Communication Skills

The big idea

Communication is the process of sharing information, ideas, feelings or instructions between two or more people so that the message is understood. At work, good communication gets jobs done right the first time; poor communication causes errors, delays and conflicts. In Class 10 you revise the methods and cycle of communication, and learn what blocks it and how to remove those blocks.

COMMUNICATION CYCLE

Sender → Message (encoded) → Channel → Receiver (decodes) → Feedback back to the sender. Communication is complete only when feedback shows the message was understood.

Methods of communication

Method	What it uses	Examples
Verbal – oral	Spoken words	Face-to-face talk, phone call, video meeting
Verbal – written	Written words	Letter, e-mail, SMS, notice, report
Non-verbal	Body language and voice	Facial expressions, gestures, posture, eye contact, touch, personal space, tone and pitch (paralanguage)

Method	What it uses	Examples
Visual	Pictures and symbols	Traffic signs, charts, maps, emojis, logos

Studies of face-to-face conversations suggest that a large share of meaning comes from **tone and body language**, not just words. So keep your posture open, make eye contact, nod to show you are listening, and keep your tone friendly.

NON-VERBAL CUES AT AN INTERVIEW

Positive: sitting upright, a firm handshake (where appropriate), smiling, nodding. Negative: crossed arms, slouching, looking at the phone, tapping fingers.

The 7 Cs of effective communication

A message is effective when it is **Clear, Concise, Concrete, Correct, Coherent, Complete and Courteous**.

- **Clear** – one idea at a time, simple words.
- **Concise** – no unnecessary words.
- **Concrete** – specific facts and figures, not vague ideas.
- **Correct** – accurate facts, grammar and spelling.
- **Coherent** – logical flow, ideas connected.
- **Complete** – all the information the receiver needs.
- **Courteous** – polite and respectful.

Barriers to effective communication

Barrier	Meaning	Example / remedy
Physical	Noise, distance, poor network, bad lighting	Move to a quiet room; check the connection
Linguistic (language)	Different language, jargon, unclear words	Use simple words; avoid jargon
Interpersonal	Lack of trust, attitude, emotions between people	Listen with respect; stay calm
Organisational	Too many levels, strict rules, poor systems	Clear reporting lines, open-door policy
Cultural	Different customs, values, gestures	Learn and respect other cultures
Psychological	Stress, anger, fear, low attention	Speak when calm; be patient

NOISE IS NOT ONLY SOUND

In communication, **noise** means anything that disturbs the message: a crackling phone line, a confusing word or even the listener's worry.

Principles to overcome barriers

- Use simple language and check understanding (ask "Is that clear?").
- **Active listening**: pay full attention, do not interrupt, ask questions, summarise.
- Be respectful and keep emotions under control.
- Choose the right channel: urgent matter → phone; record needed → e-mail or letter.
- Give and accept **feedback** positively.

Writing skills (quick revision)

Good writing needs correct **parts of speech** (noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection), complete **sentences** (subject + verb + object) and well-organised **paragraphs** (one main idea, a topic sentence, supporting sentences). Sentences can be statements, questions, exclamations or commands; prefer the **active voice** in workplace writing.

EXAM PATTERN

2-mark questions often ask you to "name any four barriers" or "list the 7 Cs". Write the term in bold and add a one-line example for full marks.

Quick recap

- Communication cycle: sender, message, channel, receiver, feedback.
- Methods: verbal (oral/written), non-verbal, visual.
- 7 Cs: clear, concise, concrete, correct, coherent, complete, courteous.
- Barriers: physical, linguistic, interpersonal, organisational, cultural, psychological.
- Active listening and feedback remove most barriers.

Practice questions

1. Which element of the communication cycle tells the sender that the message was understood?
   (a) Channel (b) Encoding (c) Feedback (d) Message
2. A crackling phone line that makes words unclear is an example of a
   (a) physical barrier (b) cultural barrier (c) psychological barrier (d) organisational barrier
3. Using technical jargon with a customer who does not know it creates a
   (a) physical barrier (b) interpersonal barrier (c) organisational barrier (d) linguistic barrier
4. Which of these is NOT one of the 7 Cs of communication?
   (a) Concise (b) Creative (c) Courteous (d) Coherent
5. Tone of voice, pitch and speed of speaking are part of
   (a) written communication (b) visual communication (c) paralanguage (non-verbal communication) (d) formal communication
6. A road sign showing a zebra crossing is an example of
   (a) oral communication (b) written communication (c) non-verbal gesture (d) visual communication
7. Which is a feature of active listening?
   (a) Paying full attention and asking questions to clarify (b) Interrupting to give your own view quickly (c) Checking messages while the speaker talks (d) Planning your reply while ignoring the speaker
8. List any four barriers to effective communication with one example each.
9. Explain the communication cycle with a labelled sequence and an example.

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. b 5. c 6. d 7. a 8. see notes 9. see notes